

Lab: Thought Experiment — The Spectrum of Agency

Objective

Explore the philosophical boundaries of agency by analyzing a spectrum of candidate agents — from thermostats to humans — and examining what, if anything, distinguishes genuine agents from sophisticated reactive systems.

Part 1: The Agency Spectrum

Goal: Map the intuitive boundaries of agency.

Rank the following systems from "least agentive" to "most agentive": (a) a thermostat, (b) a bacterium performing chemotaxis, (c) a chess-playing AI, (d) a sleeping human, (e) a deliberating human. Justify your ranking using at least two criteria.

Write your response here

Part 2: The Markov Blanket Analysis

Goal: Apply the formal framework to your intuitions.

For two systems from your ranking (one you consider agentive, one not), identify their Markov Blanket components (sensory states, active states, internal states, external states). Does the formal analysis match your intuitive ranking? If not, what does the mismatch reveal?

Write your response here

Part 3: The Zombie Agent

Goal: Probe the relationship between agency and consciousness.

Imagine a "philosophical zombie agent" — a system that has all the functional properties of an Active Inference agent (Markov Blanket, active states that minimize free energy, a generative model) but no subjective experience. Is such a system an agent? Does Active Inference require consciousness for agency, or is it indifferent to the presence of experience?

Write your response here

Part 4: Collective Agency

Goal: Extend the concept of agency beyond individual organisms.

Consider a colony of ants. Individual ants have limited "cognition," yet the colony as a whole exhibits sophisticated problem-solving. Does the colony have agency? Can a Markov Blanket be drawn around the colony as a whole? What philosophical issues arise from attributing agency at multiple scales simultaneously?

Write your response here

Part 5: Synthesis and Position Defense

Goal: Articulate your own philosophical position on agency.

Write a 200-word statement addressing one of the following:

- "Agency is real and graded — thermostats have a tiny amount, humans have a lot."
- "Agency is a binary property that requires consciousness or self-awareness."
- "Agency is not a property of systems at all but a stance we adopt toward them (Dennett's intentional stance)."

Identify the strongest objection to your view and respond to it.

Write your response here

Lab Summary

Part	Skill Developed	Key Philosophical Move
1	Intuition mapping	Eliciting and articulating pre-theoretical judgments about agency
2	Formal analysis	Applying Markov Blanket formalism to test intuitions
3	Modal reasoning	Exploring the logical independence of agency and consciousness
4	Scale analysis	Examining agency at collective/superorganism scales
5	Position defense	Constructing and defending a philosophical position under objection